Git Branching Strategy & Contribution Policy

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1. GitFlow Branch Structure

- **main:** Production-ready code. Locked against direct commits; tagged with releases (e.g. v1.0).
- **develop:** Integration branch for ongoing feature aggregation.
- **feature/*:** Isolated branches for individual user stories (e.g. feature/document-intake).
- **hotfix/*:** Critical production patch branches originating from main.

2. Pull Request & Quality Policies

- Direct pushes to main and develop are strictly prohibited.
- PRs require at least one peer code review before merge approval.
- All automated tests must pass before merging.
- Merge conflicts must be resolved manually preserving strict compliance rules.